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Tips to extend the life of soldering and desoldering stations

Handling soldering and desoldering stations in the right manner is important for extending their life. Here are some tips on how you can achieve this:



1. Validate each process of soldering and set to an optimum temperature, where a better-to-best soldering takes place. Avoid setting the highest possible temperature available in a soldering station.

2. Thermal shock to the solder tip can be detrimental. Avoid excess water in the cleaning sponge, which gives thermal shock to solder tips. This practice extends the life of the solder tip.

3. Do not tap the solder tip on the table or any hard surface.

4. Do not try to sharpen the tips by rubbing or grinding when these become blunt.

—V. Ramavallabhan, management and technical consultant, JVR Consultants

lock functions at a very competitive price.” He adds, “One of the recent developments is the induction heating based hybrid soldering station. These stations use the benefits of both technologies, IR heating technology and convection, to bring out the best in soldering.”

Hot-air stations are coming with built-in turbines for easy repair applications and heating processes such as shrinking. Brushless turbine is incorporated for ideal hot air flow such that hot air temperature is controlled electronically. Rao says, “Benchtop desoldering or rework stations have the most accurate temperature controls, best thermal recovery and additional features like programmable timing.” Soldering stations come with Silver Line Technology soldering iron tips. These low-mass tips provide effective heat transfer via its silver core.

Unique closed-loop temperature control in some stations protects sensitive components. Most tips are available in three standard temperature ranges for maximum control. Ferromagnetic sensor in the tip controls temperature, therefore no adjustment is required. Rao says, “Metcal and OKi soldering systems feature SmartHeat technology, which, unlike conventional soldering irons, administers heat directly from the heater to the joint, ensuring total temperature control.”

General selection criteria

Variable temperature and replaceable hardware are the two basic

criterion for selecting soldering and desoldering stations. According to Ramavallabhan, the most important factor that buyers should consider is the cost of consumables of stations and availability of components like heaters, soldering tips and other accessories. He says, “These should be reasonably priced and easily available, otherwise the maintenance cost will be more than the cost of the actual unit.”

He adds, “Non-availability of accessories when required could cost you customer’s confidence and new opportunities.”

Wattage of the station, precision in temperature control, display of the system and reliability in after-sales support are some important parameters to be considered, notes Jain.

Plethora of options

From Chinese-made to established brands, there are a variety of soldering and desoldering stations available in the market with a plethora of interesting features. Application, budget and possible future uses are three important factors to strongly consider before purchasing a station.

PCBs are increasingly becoming lead-free today. Major manufacturers are now making use of lead-free solder-to-solder components on boards. It could be beneficial in the long run to purchase a lead-free soldering station. Most stations designed for soldering leaded solders cannot be used for lead-free solders. Choose wisely. ●